

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF KINGS

JACOB WILSON,

Plaintiff,

-against-

CITY OF NEW YORK, NEW YORK CITY
POLICE DEPARTMENT, POLICE OFFICER
DANIEL TWOHIG SHIELD # 1924, SERGEANT
JEREMY POHLAND, AND "JOHN DOES 1-5,"
PERSONS EMPLOYED BY THE CITY OF NEW
YORK,

Defendants.

To the above named Defendants:

YOU ARE HEREBY SUMMONED to answer the within verified complaint in this action and to serve a copy of your answer, or, if the complaint is not served with this summons, to serve a notice of appearance on Plaintiff's attorney within twenty (20) days after the service of summons, exclusive of the day of service or within thirty (30) days after the service is complete if this summons is not personally delivered to you within the State of New York; and in case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the notice set forth below and in the within verified complaint.

Dated: New York, New York
April 20, 2021

SUMMONS

Index No.: _____

Date Filed: _____

Plaintiff designates
Kings County
as the place of trial

The basis of venue is based on
CPLR § 504(3)

/s/ Russ Kofman

Russ Kofman, Esq.
LEBEDIN KOFMAN, LLP
Attorneys for Plaintiff
JACOB WILSON
26 Broadway, 27th Floor
New York, New York 10004
(212) 500-3273

Defendants' Addresses:

CITY OF NEW YORK, 100 CHURCH STREET, NEW YORK, NY 10007

NEW YORK CITY POLICE DEPARTMENT, 1 POLICE PLAZA, NEW YORK, NY 10038

POLICE OFFICER DANIEL TWOHIG, SHIELD # 1924, 1470 E NEW YORK AVE,
BROOKLYN, NY 11212

SERGEANT JEREMY POHLAND, 1470 E NEW YORK AVE, BROOKLYN, NY 11212

“JOHN DOES 1-5,” PERSONS EMPLOYED BY THE CITY OF NEW YORK, 100 CHURCH
STREET, NEW YORK, NY 10007

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SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF KINGS

JACOB WILSON,

Plaintiff,

-against-

VERIFIED COMPLAINT

CITY OF NEW YORK, NEW YORK CITY
POLICE DEPARTMENT, POLICE OFFICER
DANIEL TWOHIG SHIELD # 1924, SERGEANT
JEREMY POHLAND, AND "JOHN DOES 1-5,"
PERSONS EMPLOYED BY THE CITY OF NEW
YORK,

Index No.:

Defendants.

JACOB WILSON, (hereinafter the "Plaintiff"), by his attorneys, LEBEDIN KOFMAN LLP, complaining against Defendants CITY OF NEW YORK, NEW YORK CITY POLICE DEPARTMENT, POLICE OFFICER DANIEL TWOHIG SHIELD # 1924, SERGEANT JEREMY POHLAND , AND "JOHN DOES 1-5," PERSONS EMPLOYED BY THE CITY OF NEW YORK, (hereinafter collectively "Defendants"), upon information and belief, alleges as follows:

INTRODUCTION

1. Plaintiff brings this action for compensatory damages and punitive damages under the common law of the State of New York, and for compensatory damages, punitive damages, and attorney's fees pursuant to 42 U.S.C. §§ 1983 and 1988 for violation of his rights under the First, Fourth, Fifth, Sixth, and Fourteenth Amendments of the United States Constitution.

PARTIES

2. At all relevant times, Plaintiff was and is a resident of Kings County, City and State of New York.

3. At all relevant times, Defendant CITY OF NEW YORK (hereinafter the “City”) was and is a municipal corporation incorporated and existing under the laws of the State of New York.

4. At all relevant times, Defendant NEW YORK CITY POLICE DEPARTMENT (hereinafter “NYPD”) was and is an agency of Defendant City.

5. At all relevant times, Defendant City operated, controlled and managed Defendant NYPD.

6. At all relevant times, Defendant POLICE OFFICER DANIEL TWOHIG, Shield No. 1924 (hereinafter “PO Twohig”) was an officer, agent, and/or employee of Defendant City.

7. At all relevant times, Defendant SERGEANT JEREMY POHLAND, (hereinafter “Sgt Pohland”) was an officer, agent, and/or employee of Defendant City.

8. At all relevant times, the names of Defendants “JOHN DOES 1-5” (hereinafter the “Officers”) are fictitious, and are intended to be individuals engaged in law enforcement, who were involved in the arrest of Plaintiff and violated Plaintiff’s rights, whose names are presently unknown to Plaintiff.

9. At all relevant times, Defendant Officers were officers, agents and/or employees of Defendant City.

10. At all relevant times, Defendants PO Twohig, Sgt Pohland and Officers were each individually hired, trained, supervised and retained by Defendant City, including its agencies, and all supervisory officers, agents, employees, and/or contractors of Defendant City.

11. At all relevant times, Defendants were involved in violating Plaintiff’s rights, and individuals who acted in concert with them, acted or failed to act, as alleged herein, toward Plaintiff

under color of the statutes, ordinances, customs, policies, procedures, rules, and/or usage of the State and City of New York, and within the scope of their employment.

12. Defendants PO Twohig, Sgt Pohland and Officers are sued herein in both their individual and official capacities.

FACTS

13. The facts alleged in this complaint are based upon the personal observations of Plaintiff regarding events that took place in his presence, and upon information and belief, the sources thereof are documents prepared in connection with the arrest of Plaintiff and public documents and information relating thereto which are presently available to Plaintiff. The aforesaid documentary evidence is presently incomplete, as it does not include numerous documents and exhibits; therefore, the complaint has been prepared without the benefit of full discovery.

The Incident of April 20, 2018

14. On or about April 20, 2018, near Saratoga Avenue and Fulton Street, in the County of Kings, State of New York, at approximately 12:00 p.m., Defendants PO Twohig, Sgt Pohland and Officers wrongfully and unlawfully searched, seized, and arrested Plaintiff by Defendants, their agents, servants, and/or employees, without probable cause or justification and charged with VTW § 1111(D)(1) Failure to Obey Traffic Control Signal, VTL § 402(1)(A) Improper Display of Number Plates, PL § 165.05(1) Unauthorized use of a Vehicle in the Third Degree, and PL § Criminal Possession of Stolen Property in the Fifth Degree, (hereinafter the “Arrest”).

15. At the time of the subject arrest, Plaintiff was lawfully operating his vehicle, posing no immediate threat to the safety of self or others.

16. While Plaintiff was lawfully operating his vehicle, Defendants PO Twohig, Sgt Pohland and Officers pulled over Plaintiff during a traffic stop.

17. Defendants PO Twohig, Sgt Pohland and Officers approached Plaintiff in his vehicle and instructed him to exit the vehicle.

18. Plaintiff complied with all of the Defendants requests and stepped out of the vehicle.

19. Defendants PO Twohig, Sgt Pohland and Officers without probable cause or justification forcefully placed handcuffs on Plaintiff.

20. Plaintiff made numerous complaints that the handcuffs were too tight, however, Defendants PO Twohig, Sgt Pohland and Officers responded by tightening the handcuffs.

21. Plaintiff was then transferred to the 73rd precinct.

22. Defendants wrongfully commenced prosecution against Plaintiff without probable cause or justification under Docket No.: 2018KN019396. On or about July 31, 2018, the Kings County Criminal Court dismissed and sealed all charges against Plaintiff.

23. Defendants' actions and/or omissions caused Plaintiff to be wrongfully incarcerated for a period of approximately twenty-two (22) hours and make approximately three appearances in court to defend himself against the aforesaid wrongful charges.

24. Defendant's actions and/or omissions caused Plaintiff to spend copious amounts of out-of-pocket expenses, including but not limited to bail and legal fees for his criminal defense.

25. At all times relevant to this action, Defendants acted intentionally, willfully, knowingly, negligently, and with reckless disregard for, and deliberate indifference to the rights of Plaintiff.

26. The acts of Defendants prior to and during the course of the Arrest of Plaintiff were the direct result of the failure of Defendant City to properly hire, train, supervise, monitor, and discipline its officers, agents, employees and/or contractors.

27. The acts of Defendants prior to and during the course of the Arrest of Plaintiff were the direct result of policies, practices, and customs developed, implemented, enforced, encouraged, sanctioned, or tolerated by Defendant City.

28. As a result of the aforesaid acts or omissions of Defendants, Plaintiff sustained personal, physical, and emotional injuries and losses including, loss of enjoyment of life, loss of liberty, emotional distress, mental anguish, trauma, shock, fear, humiliation, embarrassment, shame, indignity, damage to his reputation, professional and economic losses, and financial costs and expenses.

29. The amount of damages sought in this action exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts that may otherwise have jurisdiction.

CAUSES OF ACTION

FEDERAL CLAIMS

FIRST CAUSE OF ACTION

MUNICIPAL LIABILITY "MONELL" CLAIM

30. Plaintiff repeats and re-alleges and incorporates by reference the allegations in paragraphs 1 through 29 above with the same force and effect as if herein set forth.

31. Defendants PO Twohig, Sgt Pohland and Officers, individually and collectively, within the scope of their employment and authority and under color of State Law, engaged in conduct that constituted customs, policies, procedures, rules, or usages of the City and which were

in violation of the rights, privileges, and immunities of Plaintiff, a citizen of the United States and resident of the State of New York, as secured by the United States Constitution.

32. The aforesaid customs, policies, procedures, rules, or usages included but were not limited to: failure to properly investigate before effecting an arrest; utilizing unnecessary and excessive force; failure to ensure that use of force by police officers is properly reported and investigated; failure to appropriately discipline police officers who utilize unnecessary and excessive force, as well as those who supervise said officers; failure to implement measures to ensure that officers are appropriately supervised by qualified and well-trained staff; and failure to intervene when employees, officers, agents, and/or contractors violate well-established statutory and constitutional rights.

33. The aforesaid unlawful policies and practices in tolerating such misconduct resulted in the subject Arrest rendering Defendant City liable to Plaintiff pursuant to Monell v. City of New York, 436 U.S. 658 (1978), and under 42 U.S.C. §1983.

34. The aforesaid conduct was consistent with the institutionalized practices of Defendant NYPD, which were known and previously sanctioned by Defendant City.

35. Despite knowledge of the institutionalized practices of Defendant NYPD, Defendant City took no effective actions to end or prevent such practices.

36. Defendant City had prior notice of the injurious actions and practices of Defendants PO Suarez, PO Boyce, and Officers but took no effective actions to end or prevent the aforesaid Defendants from committing such practices.

37. Defendant City had prior notice that Defendants PO Twohig, Sgt Pohland and Officers had inadequate training regarding the applicable provisions of the Penal Law of the State

of New York, Departmental policy, other applicable laws and federal and state statutory and constitutional protections, but took no effective actions to ensure that the aforesaid Defendants were provided with adequate or appropriate training.

38. Defendant City authorized, tolerated, and ratified the misconduct of employees, officers, agents, and/or contractors, and of Defendants PO Twohig, Sgt Pohland and Officers, specifically, by failing to: discipline employees, officers and agents; take adequate precautions in screening, hiring, educating, informing, training, supervising, promoting, and retaining employees, officers, and agents; and failing to establish and maintain a meaningful system for responding to complaint of misconduct, all of which constitute deliberate indifference by Defendant City to Plaintiff's rights secured by the United States Constitution, and deliberate indifference to the physical safety and well-being of Plaintiff.

39. As a direct and proximate cause of Defendants' acts and/or omissions, Plaintiff was caused to suffer great pain and mental anguish, great humiliation and fear, and further pecuniary damages and legal costs in an amount that exceeds the jurisdictional limitation of all lower courts and in an amount to be determined at a trial of this action.

40. The conduct of Defendants set forth above and complained of herein exhibited such a high degree of moral culpability that it renders Defendant City liable to Plaintiff for punitive damages.

SECOND CAUSE OF ACTION
PURSUANT to 42 U.S.C. § 1983 (FALSE ARREST)

41. Plaintiff repeats and re-alleges and incorporates by reference the allegations in paragraphs 1 through 40 above with the same force and effect as if herein set forth.

42. At all times relevant herein the conduct of the Defendants were subject to 42 U.S.C. §§ 1983, 1985, 1986, and 1988.

43. The detention and arrest of Plaintiff without probable cause and without a lawful warrant was an abuse of power that constituted a seizure within the meaning of the Fourth Amendment of the United States Constitution and was an act taken by Defendants PO Twohig, Sgt Pohland and Officers with a deliberate indifference to Plaintiff's rights and privileges. The seizure and deprivation of Plaintiff's liberty was unreasonable and without due process of law, in violation of the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments of the United States Constitution.

44. Acting under the color of law, Defendants achieved a denial of Plaintiff's rights, privileges or immunities secured by the United States Constitution or by Federal law, to wit:

- a. By depriving Plaintiff of his liberty without due process of law, by taking Plaintiff into custody and holding him there against Plaintiff's will.
- b. By making an unreasonable search and seizure of Plaintiff's property without due process of law.
- c. By conspiring for the purpose of impeding and hindering the due course of justice, with intent to deny Plaintiff equal protection of laws.
- d. By refusing or neglecting to prevent such deprivations and denials to Plaintiff thereby depriving Plaintiff of the rights, privileges, and immunities as guaranteed by the Fourth, Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States.

45. Defendant City negligently trained Defendants PO Twohig, Sgt Pohland and Officers.

46. That by reason of the foregoing, Plaintiff suffered physical and psychological injuries, traumatic stress, post-traumatic stress disorder, mental anguish, economic damages including attorney's fees, damages to reputation, shame, humiliation, and indignity. All of said injuries may be permanent.

THIRD CAUSE OF ACTION
PURSUANT to 42 U.S.C. § 1983 (DETENTION AND CONFINEMENT)

47. Plaintiff repeats and re-alleges and incorporates by reference the allegations in paragraphs 1 through 46 above with the same force and effect as if herein set forth.

48. As a result of Defendants' concerted unlawful and malicious detention and confinement of Plaintiff, Defendants deprived Plaintiff of both his right to liberty without due process of law and his right to equal protection of the laws, and the due course of justice was impeded in violation of the Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments of the Constitution of the United States and 42 U.S.C. 1983.

49. That by reason of the foregoing, Plaintiff suffered physical and psychological injuries, traumatic stress, post-traumatic stress disorder, mental anguish, economic damages including attorney's fees, damages to reputation, shame, humiliation, and indignity. All of said injuries may be permanent.

FOURTH CAUSE OF ACTION
PURSUANT to 42 U.S.C. § 1983 (REFUSING OR NEGLECTING TO PREVENT)

50. Plaintiff repeats and re-alleges and incorporates by reference the allegations in paragraphs 1 through 49 above with the same force and effect as if herein set forth.

51. At all times relevant to the complaint, Defendants PO Twohig, Sgt Pohland and Officers, as police officers of Defendant NYPD were acting under the direction and control of Defendant City.

52. Acting under the color of law and pursuant to official policy Defendants PO Twohig, Sgt Pohland and Officers, Defendant NYPD and Defendant City knowingly, recklessly and/or with gross negligence failed to instruct, supervise, control, and discipline on a continuing basis Defendant policy officers in their duties to refrain from:

- a. Unlawfully and maliciously harassing a citizen who was acting in accordance with his constitutional and statutory rights, privileges, and immunities;
- b. Unlawfully and maliciously arresting, imprisoning, and prosecuting a citizen who was acting in accordance with his constitutional and statutory rights, privileges, and immunities;
- c. Conspiring to violate the rights, privileges, and immunities guaranteed to Plaintiff by the Constitution and the laws of the United States and the laws of the State of New York;
- d. Otherwise depriving Plaintiff of his constitutional and statutory rights, privileges and immunities.

53. Defendant City had knowledge of or had they diligently exercised their duties to instruct, supervise, control, and discipline on a continuing basis, should have had knowledge that the wrongs conspired to be done, as heretofore alleged, were about to be committed. Defendant City had the power to prevent or aid in preventing the commission of said wrongs, could have

done so by reasonable diligence, and knowingly, recklessly, or with gross negligence failed or refused to do so.

54. Defendants City and Defendant NYPD directly or indirectly under color of law approved or ratified the unlawful deliberate, malicious, reckless, and wanton conduct of Defendant Officers heretofore described.

55. As a direct and proximate cause of the negligent and intentional acts of Defendants City and Defendant NYPD as set forth in paragraphs 1 to 54 above, Plaintiff suffered physical injury, loss of income, and severe mental anguish in connection with the deprivations of his constitutional and statutory rights guaranteed by the Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments of the Constitution of the United States and protected by 42 U.S.C. § 1983.

56. That by reason of the foregoing, Plaintiff suffered physical and psychological injuries, traumatic stress, post-traumatic stress disorder, mental anguish, economic damages including attorney's fees, damage to reputation, shame, humiliation, and indignity. All of the said injuries may be permanent.

FIFTH CAUSE OF ACTION
PURSUANT to 42 U.S.C. § 1983 (MALICIOUS PROSECUTION)

57. Plaintiff repeats and re-alleges and incorporates by reference the allegations in paragraphs 1 through 56 above with the same force and effect as if herein set forth.

58. That Defendants with malicious intent, arrested Plaintiff and initiated criminal proceedings despite the knowledge that Plaintiff had committed no crime.

59. That all charges against Plaintiff have been dismissed.

60. That there was no probable cause for the arrests and criminal proceedings. That by reason of Defendants' acts and omissions, Defendants, acting under the color of state law and

within the scope of their authority, in gross and wanton disregard of Plaintiff's rights, deprived Plaintiff of his liberty when they maliciously prosecuted him and subjected him to unlawful, illegal and excessive detentions, in violation of his rights pursuant to the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments of the United States Constitution.

61. That upon information and belief, Defendants had a policy and/or custom of maliciously prosecuting individuals despite the lack of probable cause. Thus, as a result of the above described policies and customs, Plaintiff was maliciously prosecuted despite the fact that he had committed no violation of the law.

62. That upon information and belief, the policy and/or custom of Defendant City to inadequately hire, train, supervise, discipline and/or terminate their officers, staff, agents and employees, thereby failing to adequately discourage further constitutional violations on the part of their officers, staff, agents, and employees.

63. That as a result of the above described policies and customs, Defendant City, its staff, agents and employees of Defendant City believe that their actions would not be properly monitored by supervisory officers and that misconduct would not be investigated or sanctioned, but would be tolerated.

64. That the above described policies and customs demonstrate a deliberate indifference on the part of the policymakers of Defendant City to the constitutional rights of arrestees and were the cause of the violations of Plaintiff's rights alleged herein.

65. That in so acting, Defendant City abused its power and authority as policymaker of Defendant NYPD under the color of State and/or local law.

66. That upon information and belief, in 2018, Defendant City had a policy or routine practice of alleging facts against persons for the purpose of charging crimes they did not commit.

67. That by reason of the foregoing, Plaintiff suffered physical and psychological injuries, traumatic stress, post-traumatic stress disorder, mental anguish, economic damages including attorney's fees, damage to reputation, shame, humiliation, and indignity. All of said injuries may be permanent.

SIXTH CAUSE OF ACTION
PURSUANT to 42 U.S.C. § 1983 (EXCESSIVE FORCE)

68. Plaintiff repeats and re-alleges and incorporates by reference the allegations in paragraphs 1 through 67 above with the same force and effect as if herein set forth.

69. That the incident that resulted from the intentional application of physical force by Defendants constituted a seizure. That the use of excessive force in effectuating the seizure was unreasonable under the circumstances.

70. That Defendants has no legal cause or reason to use excessive force in effectuating Plaintiff's arrest.

71. That Defendants violated Plaintiff's Fourth and Fourteenth Amendment right to be free from unreasonable seizure when they used excessive force against him.

72. That at the time of the arrest or while in custody, Plaintiff did not pose a threat to the safety of the arresting officers.

73. That Plaintiff did not actively resisting arrest or attempting to evade arrest.

74. The Defendant NYC, through its officers, agents, and employees, unlawfully subjected Plaintiff to excessive force while effectuating his arrest.

75. That Defendants' actions were grossly disproportionate to the need for action and were unreasonable under the circumstances.

76. That by reason of Defendants' acts and omissions, acting under color of law and within the scope of Defendants' authority, in gross and wanton disregard of Plaintiff's rights, subjected Plaintiff to excessive force while effectuating his arrest, in violation of Plaintiff's rights pursuant to the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments of the United States Constitution.

77. That Defendants had the opportunity to intervene, and failed to do so, to prevent violations of Plaintiff's civil rights, including but not limited to the right to be free from the application of excessive force.

78. That upon information and belief, in 2018, Defendants and NYC had a policy or routine practice of using excessive force when effectuating arrests.

79. That upon information and belief, it was the policy and/or custom of Defendant NYC to inadequately train, supervise, discipline, and/or terminate their officers, staff, agents and employees, thereby failing to adequately discourage further constitutional violations on the part of their officers, staff, agents and employees.

80. That as a result of the above described policies and customs, the officers, staff, agents and employees of Defendant NYC, believed that their actions would not be properly monitored by supervisory officers and that misconduct would not be investigated or sanctioned, but would be tolerated.

81. That the above described policies and customs demonstrate a deliberate indifference on the part of the policymakers of Defendant NYC to the constitutional rights of arrestees and were the cause of the violations of Plaintiff's rights alleged herein.

82. That by reason of the foregoing, Plaintiff suffered physical and psychological injuries, traumatic stress, post-traumatic stress disorder, mental anguish, economic damages including attorney's fees, damage to reputation, shame, humiliation, and indignity. All said injuries may be permanent.

WHEREFORE, Plaintiff demands judgment against Defendants CITY OF NEW YORK, NEW YORK CITY POLICE DEPARTMENT, POLICE OFFICER DANIEL TWOHIG SHIELD # 1924, SERGEANT JEREMY POHLAND , AND "JOHN DOES 1-5," PERSONS EMPLOYED BY THE CITY OF NEW YORK, individually and collectively, on all causes of action, in an amount which exceeds the jurisdiction limitations of all lower courts and in an amount to be determined at the trial of this action, together with all costs and interest, and for such other relief as this Court may deem just and proper.

Dated: New York, New York
April 20, 2021

/s/ Russ Kofman
Russ Kodman, Esq.
LEBEDIN KOFMAN, LLP
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ATTORNEY'S VERIFICATION

I, the undersigned, am an attorney duly admitted to practice law in the courts of the State of New York, and affirm the following to be true:

I am a member of Lebedin Kofman, LLP, the attorneys of record for Plaintiff.

I have read the foregoing Complaint, and know the allegations of fact stated therein, that the stated allegations of fact are true to my own knowledge except as to those allegations stated to be on information and belief, and as to those matters, I believe them to be true.

The grounds of my belief as to all matters stated to be upon information and belief are conversations with Plaintiff, my review of the documents contained in files maintained by my office in connection with this matter, and any investigation of the relevant facts and circumstances.

The reason I make this verification instead of Plaintiff is that Plaintiff is not presently within the county where Lebedin Kofman, LLP maintains its offices.

Dated: New York, New York
April 20, 2021

/s/ Russ Kofman

Russ Kofman, Esq.